

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Board: 5

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 5 

Declarer: South

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 6
♥ 6 3
♦ Q 10 9 8 4
♣ Q J 10 6

♠ Q J 10 5

♥ K 5 4

♦ A K 6

♣ A 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 9 8 2

♥ J 10 9 8

♦ J 2

♣ 9 7 3

♠ 7 4 3

♥ A Q 7 2

♦ 7 5 3

♣ K 8 4

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North

♠Q. If West wins with a doubleton ♠ honor you will only be able to win 1 ♠ since East will sit there with ♠ A 9 or ♠ K 9 behind your ♠ J 10.

Instead, win the first trick in dummy and play a small ♠ toward the ♠ Q J 10. West will play low and East must take his ♠ honor. But you can win his return, enter dummy and play another ♠ toward your hand. If you are lucky, West will be forced to play an honor and you can toss your ♠ 5.

to see if you were lucky.

This plan, leading toward your ♠ holding twice, will succeed the majority of the time.

It only fails if East holds 4 or more ♠s headed by A K.

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

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You may disagree with the Stayman bid on 3-4-3-3 distribution. In any case, 2NT is invitational, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥J.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3/4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7/8

East's ♥J lead probably means ♥s won't be 3-3, so you will need to get 2 ♠ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick and plunk down the

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 8 6 5
♥ K 7 2
♦ A Q 9
♣ 10 6 4 3

♠ K Q 10 3

♥ Q 10 6 3

♦ K 7 5 2

♣ 8

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 7 4

♥ A 9 4

♦ 8 6 3

♣ A K Q 9

♠ J 9 2

♥ J 8 5

♦ J 10 4

♣ J 7 5 2

West	North	East	South
		1NT	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			
3NT by East			

A square hand, no 4-card Major, and 9 points. This is the very hand that the book said to bid 2NT with. And when you do, partner says 3NT which you pass.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♣2. You must be living right, South gives you a trick with the opening lead.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

You got a good break on the opening lead, now you need only one more winner. There is **NO CHANCE** of creating another winner in ♠s, ♥s or ♣s, so your second good break is that you know it will have to be ♦s.

You **COULD** lead toward dummy's ♦Q, finessing South for the ♦K. That would be a perfectly good 50% chance. But there is an even better play if you look carefully.

Play a ♦ from your hand and if South plays low insert the ♦9. Much of the time North will win with the ♦J or ♦10. If so you are no worse off, you play South for the ♦K. But if it happens that South was dealt both the ♦J and ♦10 then North will have to win that trick with the ♦K, or perhaps not even win it at all!

As you see, the Deep Finesse of the ♦9 pays off here, where the straightforward finesse of the ♦Q would lose the contract. Two chances are definitely better than one.

But what if South has played the ♦10, splitting his honors?

You would put on dummy's ♦Q and North would win the ♦K. But you aren't down yet! Later you lead another ♦ toward dummy's ♦A 9 and finesse South for the ♦J.

Board 5

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 9 3

♥ K 7 6 4

♦ A

♣ J 10 3

♠ K 7 6 2

♥ 5

♦ K J 8 7 4 3

♣ 7 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 5

♥ Q 10 9 8 2

♦ 9 2

♣ 9 8 6 5 4

♠ A 8 4

♥ A J 3

♦ Q 10 6 5

♣ A K Q

West	North	East	South
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♦	Pass	5♦
All Pass			

5♦ by South

This looks so easy let's check it by trying a winner count as well. Five ♦s (after ♦A is gone), the ♠ A K, the ♥A and the ♣ A K Q. Yes that adds up to 11 winners.

Is there ANY danger here at all?

Whenever a hand looks easy you should ask yourself what could go wrong. And here the only thing that could go wrong is if one of your ♠ winners gets ruffed. So how can you prevent that possibility?

If East has a singleton ♠, and West has the ♦A you might go down if you win the first trick in your hand. West will take his ♦A and play the ♠J. If you go up with dummy's ♠K East will ruff and you will still have a ♠ loser.

The simple solution is to win the first trick with dummy's ♠K. Now when West wins the ♦A and leads another ♠ it's a different situation. East may well ruff, but if he does you will just play a low card - East will have ruffed your ♠ **LOSER**.

You are a little unlucky that East has a singleton ♠.

But you are very lucky that you took the time to read this hand so you know how to play safely!

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 3♦. Partner now bids 4♦.

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Partner wouldn't bypass 3NT unless he was pretty distributional. His bid is invitational and you have excellent ♦ help so you try 5♦.

South plays 5♦. West leads the ♠Q.

You may be wishing partner had said 3NT. But at 3NT West might have led a ♥, then you'd be wishing you were in 5♦.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2